exonerated the accused in the ISRO spy case. I took an extra couple of minutes to say all that, but Salve sat patiently.

During the course of the case hearing, Justice Mukerjee appeared to be having an information overload, especially after Shanti Bhushan's convoluted arguments. On one such occasion, Justice Mukerjee wondered aloud, 'What's this all about?'

At this point, Salve stood up. 'Sexual perversion of a Kerala Police Officer, your honour,' he said. And he launched himself into a compelling argument, in parts quoting verbatim from my nine-minute briefing. This man, who I thought was not listening to me during the client-lawyer meetings, was making mental notes of everything. I was in the fourth row of the visitors' gallery, on the front row were Kerala Police Officers Siby Mathews and Senkumar.

After Salve's one-hour non-stop argument and a many appearances of Muralidhar who made an equally forceful presentation of facts, I was confident of a favourable verdict from the Supreme Court. By now more than two years had passed.

The judgment was reserved sometime in early 1998, and I was in the court corridor with Sasi and others, when I noticed Siby Mathews at a distance. Senkumar brought him tea, and Mathews, visibly disturbed by the course the case had taken, told him to 'get lost'. Shanti Bhushan passed by us, then came back to tell me, 'I hope you win the case.'

The judgment came on 29 April 1998 when I was in Tenkasi in Tamil Nadu for my nephew's wedding. After the ceremony at Ilanji temple, I was having lunch with my wife Meena, our son and a few relatives when Advocate Muralidhar called.

'We've won the case,' he said.

I must have gone into a trance. I didn't register the rest of what Muralidhar was saying; he kept talking in an animated voice. Only much later, after repeatedly reading the order did it sink in that the Supreme Court has finally delivered me justice.

The order was critical of the Kerala Government. Here are some portions from Justice M K Mukherjee's judgment dated 29 April 1998: